



## DR. VIKRAM SHAH

FOUNDER & CHAIRMAN,  
SHALBY HOSPITALS

**(FY26 REVENUE: ₹1,141 CR)**

**Orthopaedic surgeon Dr. Vikram Shah founded Shalby Hospitals in Ahmedabad in 1994, starting with a modest six-bed hospital that later grew into a multi-specialty healthcare network. Alongside building the organisation, he developed the “Zero Technique” for total knee replacement surgery, an approach aimed at reducing operating time and improving patient recovery, which became closely associated with Shalby’s clinical reputation. Later, it diversified well beyond its orthopaedic roots into multiple additional specialities, while still keeping joint replacement surgery as a core, defining area of clinical focus.**

fordability and compassionate care should come together under one roof. “I never wanted to build just another hospital; I wanted to build a healthcare institution,” he says.

Since opening Aakash Healthcare in Dwarka in 2017, he has expanded its clinical footprint while adding speciality services. His ambitions have also extended beyond India. In November 2022, Aakash Healthcare became the first Indian hospital brand to acquire and operate a hospital overseas, taking over a 50-bed multi-speciality facility in Tashkent, with an initial investment of \$3.5 million. The company has said it plans to invest up to \$10 million in the venture over three years and is exploring opportunities in markets including Bahrain, Mongolia, and Fiji.

For Dr. Chaudhry, growth is “not just about adding beds, but about building institutions that combine advanced treatment with operational efficiency and a strong clinical culture.” The group also plans to expand its capacity to more than 1,500 beds by the end of 2028.

Dr. Arvind Lal, Chairman of Dr Lal PathLabs, took a related but distinct path, transforming his father’s single pathology laboratory into a nationwide diagnostics network. He joined the family business in 1977 after teaching at the Armed Forces Medical College and led the company’s expansion through a hub-and-spoke model, home sample collection, and digital reporting.

## A DIFFERENT CHOICE

Not every senior doctor of the previous generation chose to become a doctorpreneur, and Dr. Ashok Seth is a case in point. The Chairman of Fortis Escorts Heart Institute in New Delhi established Max Heart Institute from the ground up in 2004, but unlike many of his contemporaries, he consciously chose not to build a hospital enterprise. Several of his colleagues went on to do so; he decided his greatest contribution lay elsewhere.

Whether they built hospital chains or remained focused on clinical practice, each was responding to a shortcoming they had personally encountered in India’s healthcare system. The buildings, the beds and the balance sheets are recent. Long before hospitals became an investment story, they were a doctor’s answer to a problem that needed solving. That is the legacy this generation leaves behind.

“I felt that my clinical leadership would be better utilised in practising cardiology, advancing patient care, teaching and training generations of interventional cardiologists, and furthering innovative techniques rather than in building hospital businesses,” says Dr Seth. **BT**

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